

Adjacencies

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ABSTRACT

“Adjacencies” (2022 — ongoing) is an exercise in distance collaboration and creative exchange between artists and animation classes at Carnegie Mellon University and Yale School of Art. The exchange is modeled upon the principles of *cadavre exquis*, wherein participants contribute to a process of exchange that results in a collective assembly of animation. This project leverages the affordances of distance learning platforms, file sharing, and thematic prompts as organizing structures to guide student participation, collaboration, and learning across groups of artists located in physically remote locations.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Applied computing** → Arts and humanities; Fine Arts; Arts and humanities; Media Arts; Education; Collaborative learning; Education; Distance learning.

KEYWORDS

Education, Art, Engaging Education Techniques and Assignments

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1 OVERVIEW

“Adjacencies” (2022 — ongoing) was born out of an interest to bridge undergraduate animation curriculum and artist communities between Carnegie Mellon University School of Art and Yale University School of Art. On the heels of the global pandemic, distance learning platforms have become ever more standard pedagogical tools, offering affordances and flexibilities previously less considered, or underutilized, in higher education — especially in studio-based schools of art. As curricular programs returned to in-person learning, we considered the affordances of distance learning platforms as a means to enhance and expand the studio-classroom, span institutional confines, and foster development of expanded artistic community.

Looking to histories of artistic exchange and collaboration, we considered Surrealist games of chance [Brotchie and Gooding,

1995] and the intermedia arts initiatives of Black Mountain College [Díaz, 2014] — particularly, the practices of parallel collaboration demonstrated by artists John Cage, Merce Cunningham, and Robert Rauschenberg, wherein works developed separately and simultaneously by individual artists were juxtaposed through the organizing frameworks of live events, performances, or happenings. Stan VanDerbeek, another Black Mountain College artist, offered precedents for collectivity and exchange, exemplified in works such as *Movie Mural* (1965 — 68), *Movie Drome* (1964 — 65), and *Fax Mural* (1970). Both *Movie Mural* and *Movie Drome* present collage-like tapestries of moving image through their simultaneous presentations of imbricated projection surfaces, each work emphasizing disparate arrangements of visual content, color registers, and overlapping sequential rhythms. In particular, *Movie Drome* was designed as a democratizing answer to industrialized cinematic forms with a view toward a global web of moving image content shared through a vast telecommunications network — an artist anticipating the internet through the materials of his time [Sutton, 2015]. While networked communications and the collective assembly of moving image have an apparent relationship to our project, we note an observation shared by historian Gloria Sutton in which the tapestry-like presentation has a leveling effect on its individual elements, emphasizing the network itself as content rather than the individual subjectivity of any contributing element [Sutton, 2003]. We challenged ourselves to find an organizing apparatus that could balance the collective whole and individual contributions.

One answer came through the example of an anonymously produced piece of animation from 1928, the explicit cartoon *Eveready Harton in Buried Treasure* — a collective assembly of animation supposedly produced for Winsor McCay’s birthday by animators at three New York studios, including Max Fleischer, Paul Terry, and Mutt and Jeff studios [Cohen, 2013]. Another example came through the format of television itself, wherein the notion of *adjacencies* was adopted as an organizing framework. *Adjacencies* refer to the interstitial time-blocks that are allocated for commercial programming in television. Within this structure, individual contributions can be viewed in relation to the collective whole through the framework of channel surfing, and individual snippets of animation — organized into five, ten, or fifteen-second increments — can be experienced sequentially as their own independent statements.

Thematic prompts were established to guide the creation of the short animation snippets. Participating animators were provided the theme and brief guidelines by the organizers, including material constraints such as duration, aspect ratio, and a particular mode of animation. Participants are asked to source fifteen seconds of thematically relevant audio to exchange with members of their partnering class. The partnering class creates animation in response to the provided audio snippets and then contributes their works back to the collective assembly. Interstitial elements and visual

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effects rendered by students and the instructors are utilized to unify the individual contributions into a collective whole. The collective assembly is then presented to future classes as a prompt to start the process anew.

In the first three years of offering this project, material guidelines have included techniques in stop-motion animation, hand-drawn and 2D computer animation, and hybrid forms of digital animation and collage. Within these loose parameters, individual approaches vary widely and surprising relationships are revealed through the juxtaposition of highly subjective and idiomatic techniques. At its core, the project operates as a device for participants and organizers alike to make discoveries through rules-based practice, chance protocols, social exchange, and collective assembly.

2 METADATA

Classifications include: (1) Animation, (2) Fundamentals, (3) Graphics & Interfaces, (4) File Format, and (5) Rendering. Summary: This exercise in distance collaboration and creative exchange provides a framework for teaching animation whereby individuals respond to practical and conceptual prompts while simultaneously contributing to a collective assembly. Learning Outcomes: Participating students gain understanding of animation processes, collaborative modes of production, and collective assembly beyond cinematic conventions. Classification(s): Animation, Fundamentals, Modeling, Graphics & Interfaces, File Format, Rendering. Audience: Animation software, file sharing and distance learning platforms. Dependencies: Animation software, file sharing and distance learning platforms. Strengths: As an introductory assignment, this project fosters community both in- and out of the classroom, and exposes students to a variety of practical and conceptual approaches modeled by peers at their own institution and at their partnering institution. Weaknesses: As an introductory assignment, time constraints are felt more acutely when students are apprehensive to begin. Having examples of previous semesters' work helps establish momentum and a precedent for the initiation. Variants: Cadavre exquis offers a rich history of variations that can be explored within a single classroom, or across partnering institutions. Assessment: As an introductory assignment, students are assessed on their adherence to material guidelines, their participation in collaboration (measured through attendance, timeliness of communication, willingness to engage in open discussion with faculty and peers, and ability to meet deadlines), and their inventiveness in respect to conceptual prompts.

3 MATERIALS

Students are provided a thematic prompt (to be determined by instructors, or by democratic classroom process); material guidelines (specific mode/s of animation, specific software or tools to be used, duration, aspect ratio, file format); students are asked to source thematically relevant sound samples for exchange; for historical and cultural context, students are provided models for collaboration and exchange, such as examples of Surrealist games or historical examples aforementioned in this paper.

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